government’s policies and stances on each of these dimensions.

The Doklam incident

During the summer of 2017, conflicting Sino–Indian views on Bhutan and Doklam came to a head, resulting in a 72-day military stand-off between China and India. In June, Chinese military forces began extending a road in Doklam, near the triborder juncture of China, Bhutan, and India and into disputed territory. Indian forces intervened, hindering further construction work and creating the stand-off.[41] Soon, hundreds of soldiers from both countries were involved in the deadlock, and India placed thousands more in supporting areas on heightened alert. The Indian actions were apparently carried out in co-ordination with Bhutan. A few weeks into the deadlock, China’s ambassador to India, Luo Zhaohui, argued that there was “no scope for compromise,” calling the situation “grave.”[42] Indian official statements on the stand-off were muted in comparison, urging “utmost restraint” from all parties.[43]

China and Bhutan have long disagreed over the Doklam plateau and the Jakarlung and Pasamlung valleys. In late 2016, however, the countries appeared to be moving closer to a resolution, following the 24th round of China–Bhutan border talks.[44] The issue is of great concern to India, as the India–Bhutan–China trijunction is close to the strategically important Siliguri corridor – the so-called “Chicken’s Neck” – which connects Northeast India to India proper. Seen from the Indian perspective, the standoff was about protecting strategic, vulnerable arenas such as the Siliguri corridor. Sino–Indian competition for Bhutan’s loyalties was also a factor in the standoff, and both countries have an interest in Bhutan’s hydropower industry.